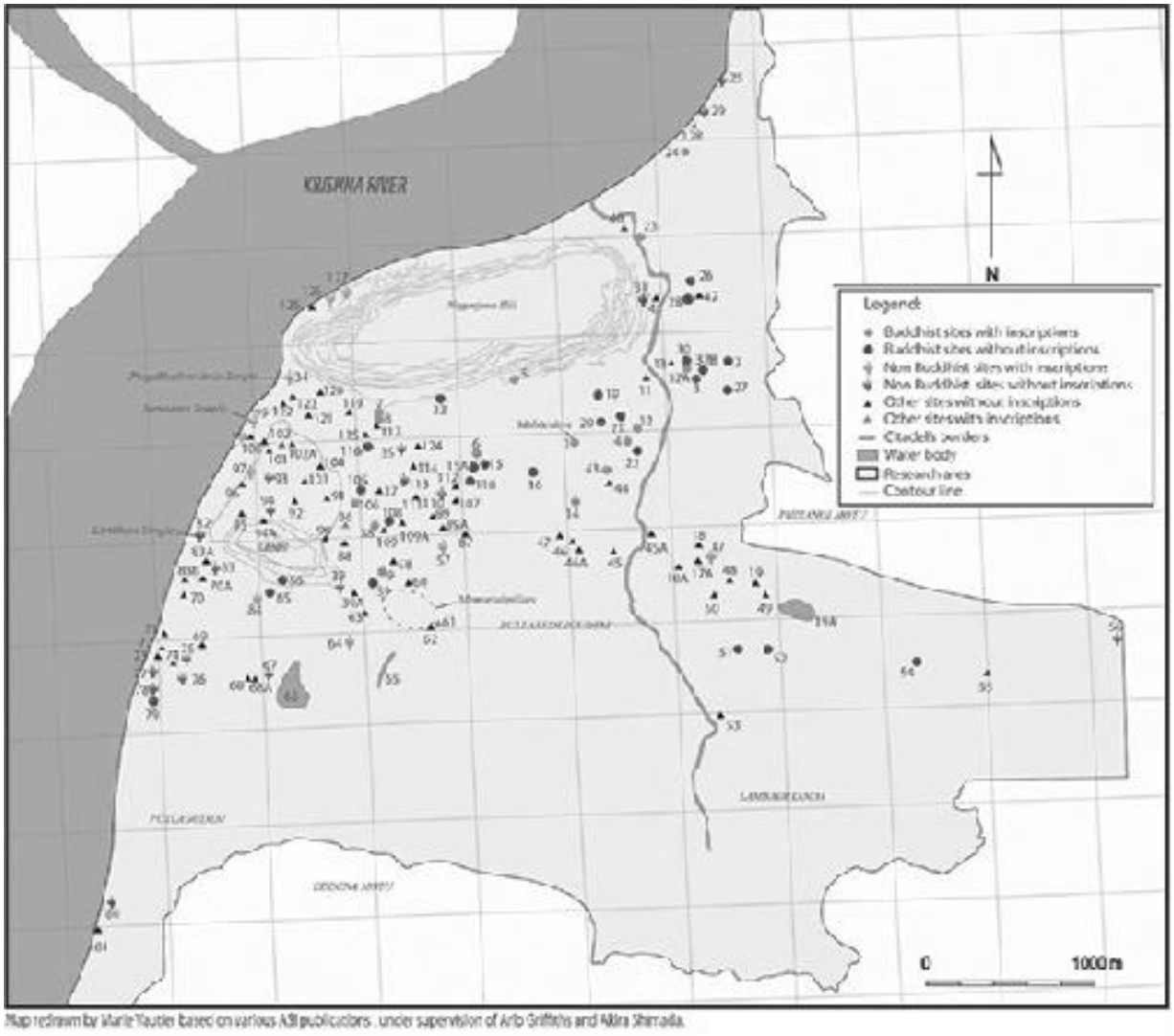


Figure 2. Nagarjunakonda site map.

Source: Early inscriptions of Āndhradeśa

In the early 1950s, with many lives lost to a severe drought in Andhra Pradesh, it became clear that the region badly needed an irrigation scheme fed by a great dam. Soon, the best location for the dam was identified, which would, however, submerge Vijayapuri—arguably the most magnificent archaeological site then known in south India. A robust ‘development vs heritage’ debate took place in the Parliament. Was preserving our most iconic cultural heritage less important than a dam that